

Systems Leadership

The deep changes necessary to accelerate progress against society's most intractable problems require someone who catalyzes collective leadership.

— The Dawn of System Leadership

Where to start

Look for the larger system

Foster shared reflection and capacity for change

Recognize connected challenges.

Shift focus to the future

Where to grow

See the Whole System

Look beyond isolated problems to understand the full system and its connections.

Embrace Uncertainty

Accept complexity and lead through experimentation, learning as you go.

Listen Deeply

Create space for diverse perspectives and truly hear what others need to share.

Lead Without Authority

Influence change by building alignment and shared purpose, not relying on position.

Balance Tension

Hold the gap between reality and vision to fuel creativity and progress.

Try, learn, grow, repeat!

Scenario

Understanding the nature of a systemic challenge

Managing resistance to systemic change

Leading a multi-stakeholder collaboration

Tackling a complex sustainability challenge

Encouraging innovation in a rigid system

Navigating a polarized social issue

Responding to an urgent crisis with systemic implications

Other valuable tools

<https://doncoleman.ca>

Key tools

Cynefin Framework — A sensemaking model for challenges using *Simple*, *Complicated*, *Complex*, and *Chaotic* domains to guide you.

Theory U — A framework for guiding leaders through personal and organizational transformation.

Collective Impact Framework — Establishing shared goals, measurements, and reinforcing activities among stakeholders.

Appreciative Inquiry — Engaging stakeholders in envisioning positive future scenarios and building commitment.

Creative Tension Mapping — Identifying the gap between vision and current reality to drive innovation.

Peacekeeping Circles — A dialogue-based tool to bring conflicting parties together and foster deep listening.

Sensemaking & Scenario Planning — Analyzing emerging trends and developing strategic responses to uncertainty.

Addressing organizational silos — Systems mapping

Building trust in a fractured team — Dialogue interviews

Reforming a policy or legal framework — Adaptive leadership

Scaling an initiative across sectors — Multi-stakeholder learning journeys